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Vampire Survivors: How Simplicity Creates Complexity

Vampire Survivors is a 2D roguelike action game where players explore a boundless space whilst trying to survive waves of enemies. [1] It uses simple controls, enemies and long-term progression systems to enhance player experience that is centred around players' patience, strategic growth and growing power.

Vampire Survivors only contain one real mechanic, which is movement. The weapons and abilities that players collect over the course of the round automatically fire, which allows the player to focus on the position of the character and strategically manoeuvre through enemies and mini obstacles. The simple mechanics allow players to concentrate on the term progression of the game. Players can concentrate on upgrading items, building up their arsenal and planning weapon evolutions which extend their longevity in the game.

Player patience is an important factor in the progression of the game, as surviving is the main priority. At the beginning of the game, the playable character starts with one weapon that fires one projectile. As gameplay continues, players start to gain experience and upgrade to get stronger, which allows players to feel powerful. During the late game stage, their patience gets rewarded and the player is at their maximum power which creates satisfying gameplay, as they can defeat anything in their path. However, this does not last long.



Figure 1: Early game



Figure 2: Late game

Each round lasts 30 minutes. Around specific intervals, different enemies and waves swarm. It is not random and will always follow that same pattern, allowing the players to be prepared when they reach that time slot. Players aren't necessarily racing against time but working with it. In the early to mid-game, it's about building up the initial inventory and surviving the enemy swarms. It's only in the very late game where players reach maximum power. They only have a few minutes with that power until they are killed by Death. This end-game satisfaction makes the player crave those few minutes where they were unstoppable. Thus, they play repeatedly to reach that feeling.

The enemy design is minimal. Although there is a variety of enemies present throughout the different maps, the enemy AI is simple. They only path find toward the player and some enemies occasionally have an easily avoidable attack. Their challenge comes in trying to control the crowd, rather than the AI itself.

The in-game progression is as follows: Kill enemies -> Collect experience -> Upgrade. Players can discover weapon combinations and evolve them. Outside of gameplay, players can unlock characters and upgrade abilities. Some maps and characters can be unlocked by doing special quests in specific maps, this encourages players to replay stages and discover new items. The game constantly rewards surviving and replaying, so players always feel like they are improving even when they fail.

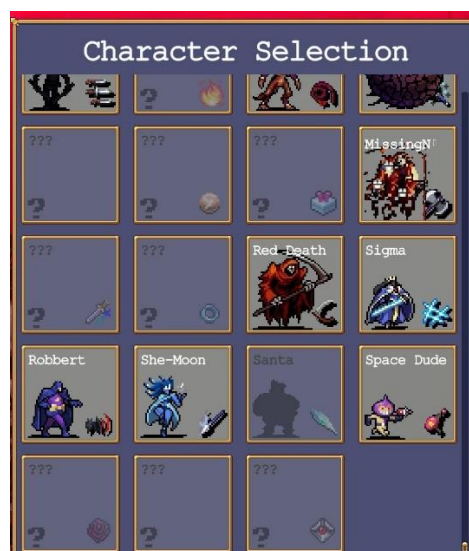


Figure 3: Unlock the character screen

 Axe	+	 Candelabrador	=	 Death Spiral
 Cross	+	 Clover	=	 Heaven Sword

Figure 4: Examples of evolutions

The simple UI is vital, as during enemy swarms, the screen becomes overcrowded to the point of being overwhelming. The UI consists of a HUD that only covers the very top of the screen. It contains the experience bar, the timer, the coin count and the enemy kill count. The health bar is directly visible above the player. This simple design allows readability during the chaos and trains the players to navigate through all the visual noise.

Vampire Survivors prove that a complex system does not always create complex gameplay. Instead, they embrace the simplicity to enhance the chaos, which creates satisfying progression and encourages long-term engagement. Therefore, simple systems can define complex gameplay and create strategic growth.